

24 Past abilities

In the past simple, "can" becomes "could."
You often use it to talk about things you
"could" do in the past, but can't do now.

-  **New language** Using "could" in the past simple
- Aa Vocabulary** Abilities and pastimes
-  **New skill** Talking about past abilities

24.1 KEY LANGUAGE "COULD" FOR PAST ABILITIES

Use "could" to talk about an ability you once had. You can
use "when" plus a time setting to say when you had the ability.



I **can't** climb trees now, but I **could** when I was younger.

You can use the present
simple for contrast.

Set the time frame with a phrase
about an age, day, or year.

The statement can be positive using "could" or
negative using "couldn't." It doesn't change with
the subject.



24.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES "COULD" FOR PAST ABILITIES

When I was a student, I **could** study all night before an exam.



I **couldn't** go to China last year because it was too expensive.



When Milo was eight, he **could** play the violin.



Last year, she **couldn't** run very far, but yesterday she ran a marathon.



24.3 HOW TO FORM "COULD" FOR PAST ABILITIES

